Linux Application Stack

User/Kernel mode

User/Kernel mode

- User mode vs Kernel mode are often used to refer to the privilege level of execution.
- This mode actually refers to the processor execution mode which is a hardware mode.
  - Might be named differently between architectures but the goal is the same
- Allows the kernel to control the full processor state (handle exceptions, MMU, etc) whereas the userspace can only do basic control and execute under the kernel supervision.

Introduction to Processes and Threads

Processes and Threads (1/2)

- A process is a group of resources that are allocated by the kernel to allow the execution of a program.
  - Memory regions, threads, file descriptors, etc.
- A process is identified by a PID (**P**rocess **ID**) and all the information that are specific to this process are exposed in `/proc/<pid>` .
  - A special file named `/proc/self` accessible by the process points to the proc folder associated to it.
- When starting a process, it initially has one execution thread that is represented by a struct task_struct and that can be scheduled.
  - A process is represented in the kernel by a thread associated to multiple resources.

Processes and Threads (2/2)

- Threads are independent execution units that are sharing common resources inside a process.
  - Same address space, file descriptors, etc.
- A new process is created using the fork() system call (man2fork) and a new thread is created using

```
pthread_create()
```

(man3pthread_create).

  - Internally, both will call `clone()` with different flags
- At any moment, only one task is executing on a CPU core and is accessible using get_current() function (defined by architecture and often stored in a register).
- Each CPU core will execute a different task.

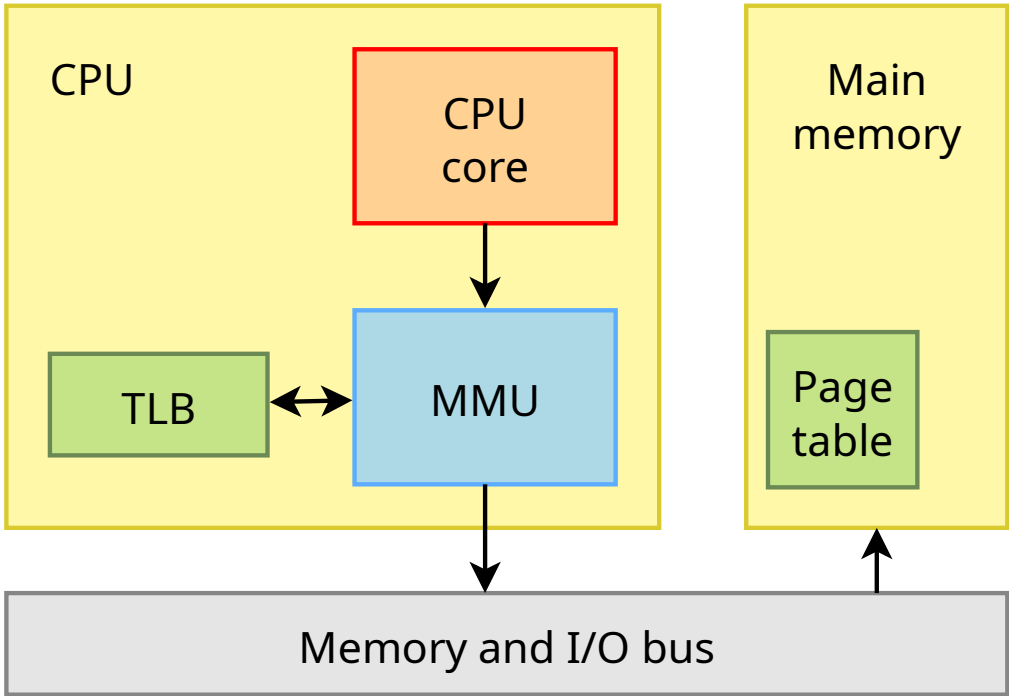
Processes and Threads (2/2)

- A task can only be executing on one core at a time.

MMU and memory management

The MMU

- Addresses accessed by the CPU are *virtual*
- The *Memory Management Unit* (MMU) translates them to *physical* addresses
- The kernel decides the translation and fills the *page table*
- The MMU reads the page table and caches recent entries in the *Translation lookaside buffers* (TLB) for zero-delay mapping

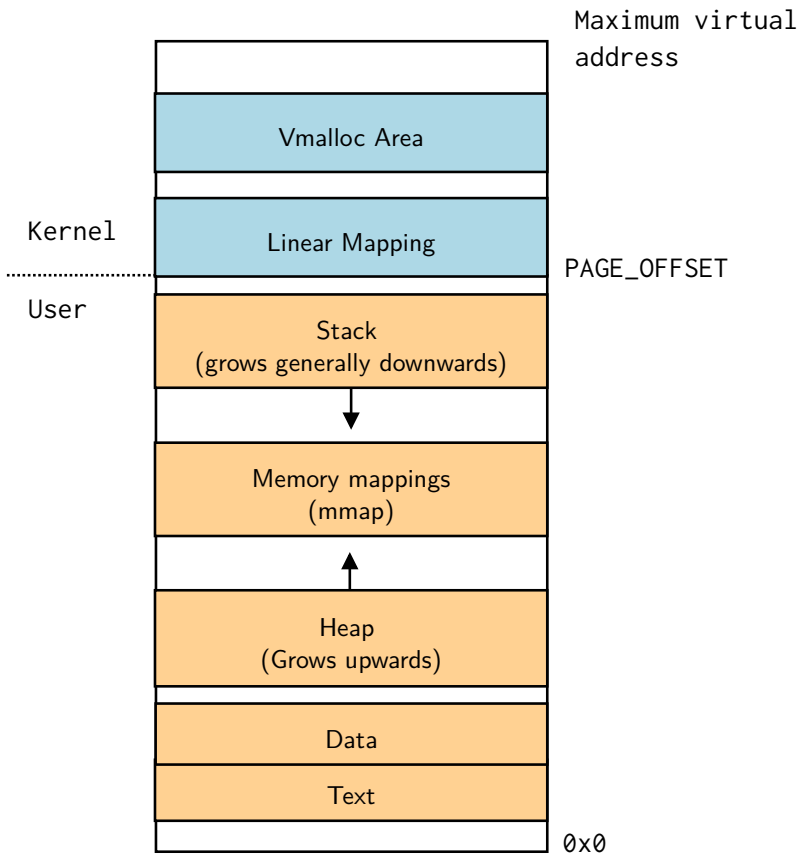


MMU and memory management

- Physical addresses can be either RAM or I/O (to access devices)
- The MMU allows to restrict access to the page mappings via some attributes
  - No Execute, Writable, Readable bits, Privileged/User bit, cacheability
- The MMU base unit for mappings is called a page
- Page size is fixed and depends on the architecture/kernel configuration.
- Linux can work without an MMU (CONFIG_MMU=n), useful for old SoCs without an MMU, but with many limitations

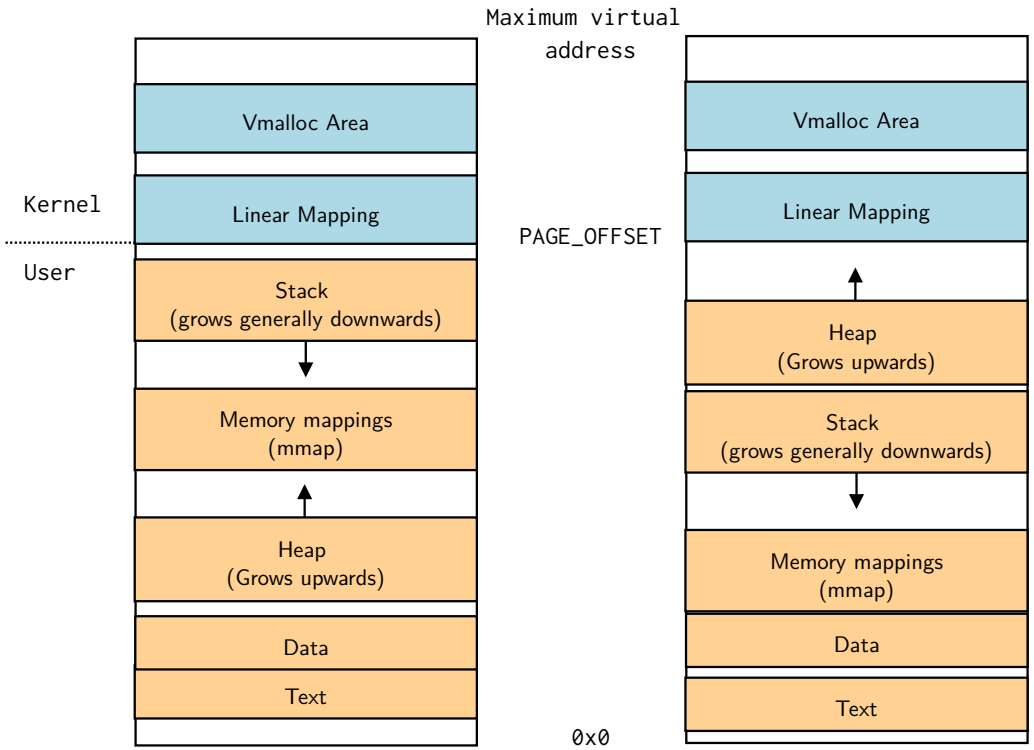
Userspace/Kernel memory layout

- Each process has its own set of virtual memory areas (`mm` field of struct task_struct).
- Also have their own page table
  - But share the same kernel mappings
- By default, all user mapping addresses are randomized to minimize attack surface (base of heap, stack, text, data, etc).
  - **A**ddress **S**pace **L**ayout **R**andomization
  - Can be disabled using `norandmaps` command line parameter



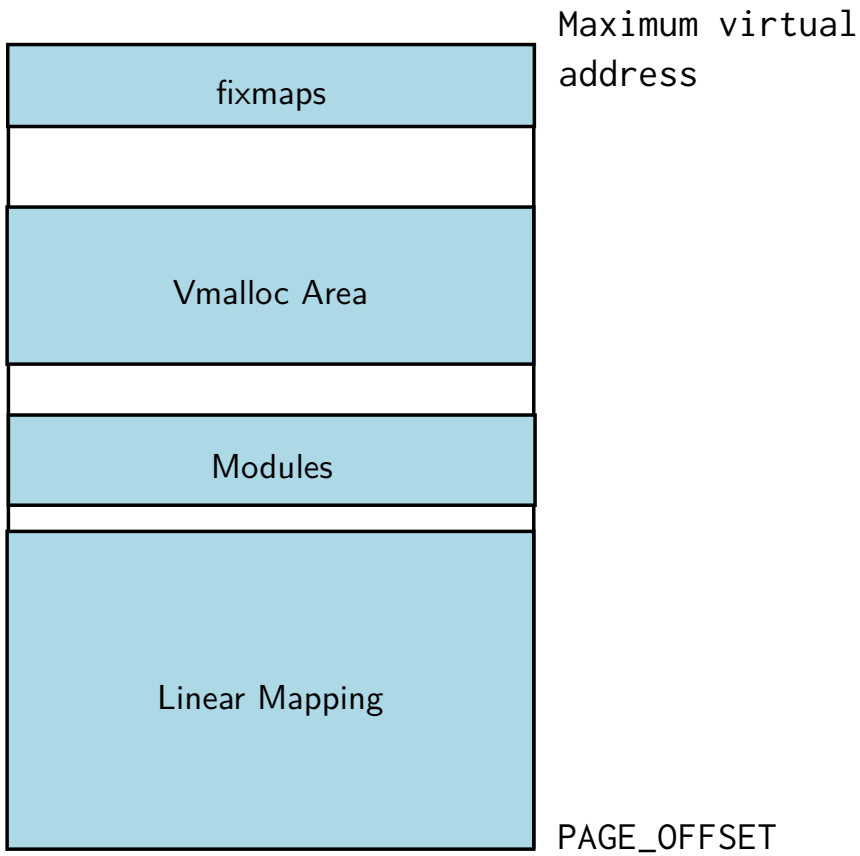
Userspace/Kernel memory layout Multiple processes have different

user memory spaces



Kernel memory map

- The kernel has it own memory mapping.
- Linear mapping is setup at kernel startup by inserting all the entries in the kernel init page table.
- Multiple areas are identified and their location differs between the architectures.
- **K**ernel **A**ddress **S**pace **L**ayout **R**andomization also allows to randomize kernel address space layout.
  - Can be disabled using `nokaslr` command line parameter



Userspace memory segments

- When starting a process, the kernel sets up several *Virtual Memory Areas* (VMA), backed by struct vm_area_struct , with different execution attributes.
- VMA are actually memory zones that are mapped with specific attributes (R/W/X).
- A segmentation fault happens when a program tries to access an unmapped area or a mapped area with an access mode that is not allowed.
  - Writing data in a read-only segment
  - Executing data from a non-executable segment
- New memory zones can be created using `mmap()` (man2mmap)
- Per application mappings are visible in */proc//maps*

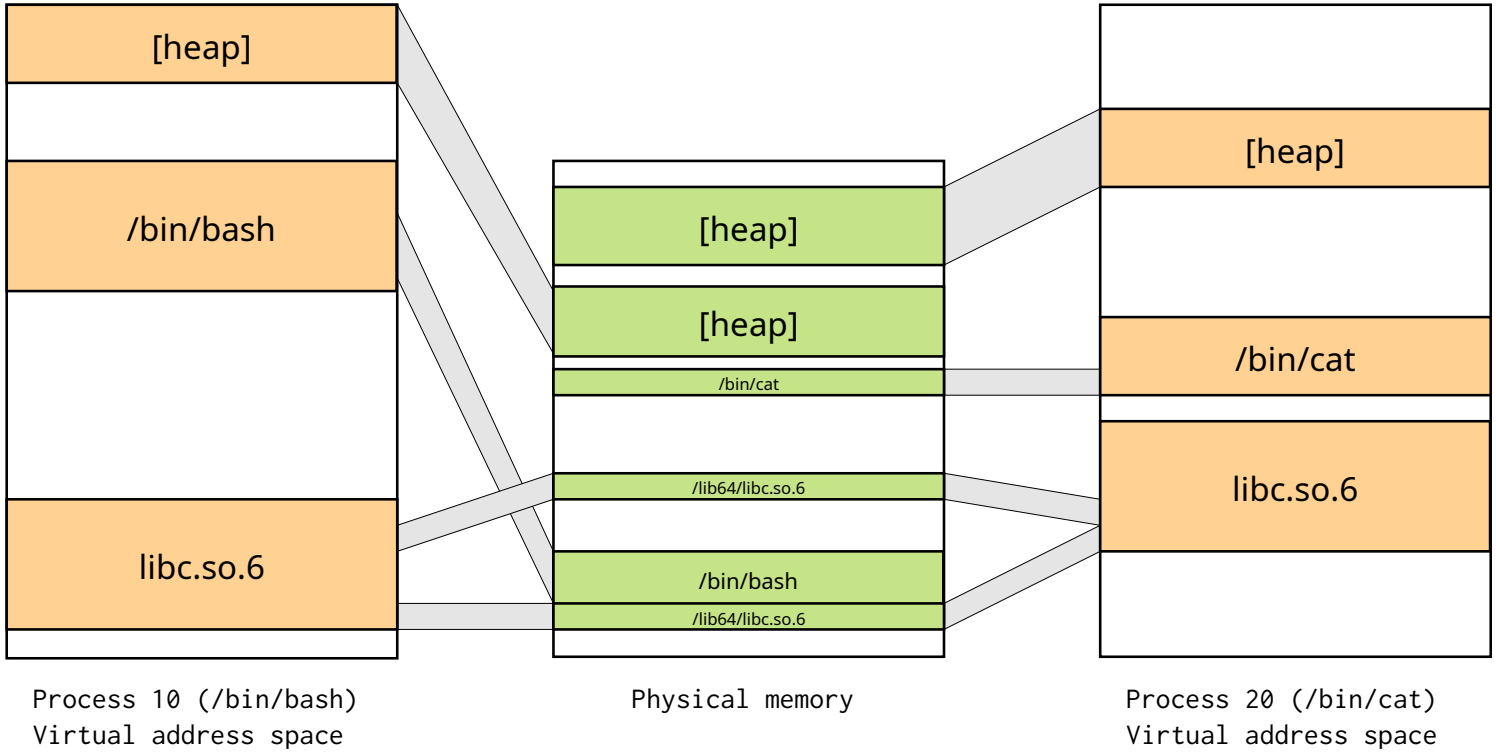
```
7f1855b2a000-7f1855b2c000 rw-p 00030000 103:01 3408650  ld-2.33.so
7ffc01625000-7ffc01646000 rw-p 00000000 00:00 0         [stack]
```

Userspace memory segments

```
7ffc016e5000-7ffc016e9000 r--p 00000000 00:00 0          [vvar]
7ffc016e9000-7ffc016eb000 r-xp 00000000 00:00 0          [vdso]
```

Virtual memory VS physical memory

- Memory segments can be shared among different processes
- Non-contiguous physical memory can be virtually contiguous



Userspace memory types

	Private	Shared
Anonymous	- stack - malloc() - brk()/sbrk() - mmap(PRIVATE,ANON)	- POSIX shm* - mmap(SHARED, ANON)
File-backed	- mmap(PRIVATE,fd) - program (code) - shared libraries	- mmap(SHARED, fd)

On-demand memory mapping (*Lazy allocation*)

1. Virtual memory is allocated when requested, but not mapped to physical memory
2. When the CPU accesses a virtual address not yet physically mapped, a *page fault* happens, and the kernel physically allocates memory
   - For file-backed mappings, implies reading from disk
3. The virtual memory is fully mapped to physical memory only if really needed
   - Allows faster program startup, avoids using memory for unused data

- Execution time not deterministic: for real-time needs, memory can be *pre-faulted*

On-demand memory mapping (L

On-demand memory mapping: page faults

- Lazy allocation is implemented based on *Page faults*

1. The CPU accesses a virtual address, valid but not yet physically mapped
   - E.g.: executes an instruction or reads/writes data
2. The MMU finds no mapping in the Page table → issues a Page fault *exception* to the CPU
3. The CPU is immediately turned in kernel mode and executes an exception vector (a function provided by the kernel)
4. The kernel checks if the virtual address is valid, finds a suitable physical page to map, fills the page (reads from disk if needed) and creates a page table entry
5. The kernel continues execution normally
6. The MMU now finds a mapping and continues

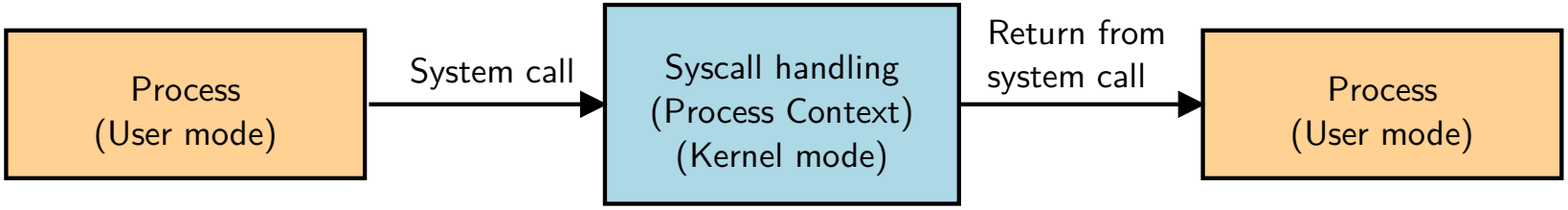
Terms for memory in Linux tools

- When using Linux tools, four terms are used to describe memory:
  - *VSS/VSZ*: Virtual Set Size (Virtual memory size, shared libraries included).
  - *RSS*: Resident Set Size (Total physical memory usage, shared libraries included).
  - *PSS*: Proportional Set Size (Actual physical memory used, divided by the number of times it has been mapped).
  - *USS*: Unique Set Size (Physical memory occupied by the process, shared mappings memory excluded).
- VSS >= RSS >= PSS >= USS.

The process context

Process context

- The *process context* can be seen as the content of the CPU registers associated to a process: execution register, stack register...
- This context also designates an execution state and allows to sleep inside kernel mode.
- A process that is executing in process context can be preempted.
- While executing in such context, the current process struct task_struct can be accessed using get_current() .



Scheduling

Scheduling

- The scheduler can be invoked for various reasons
  - On a periodic tick caused by interrupt (HZ)
  - On a programmed interrupt on tickless systems (CONFIG_NO_HZ=y)
  - Voluntarily by calling schedule() in code
  - Implicitly by calling functions that can sleep (blocking operations such as kmalloc() , wait_event()).
- When entering the schedule function, the scheduler will elect a new struct task_struct to run and will eventually call the switch_to() macro.
- switch_to() is defined by architecture code and it will save the current task process context and restore the one of the next task to be run while setting the new current task running.

Execution mode switching

Execution mode switching

- Execution mode switching is the action of changing the execution mode of the processor (Kernel $\leftrightarrow$ User).
  - Explicitly by executing system calls instructions (synchronous request to the kernel from user mode).
  - Implicitly when receiving exceptions (MMU fault, interrupts, breakpoints, etc).
- This state change will end up in a kernel entrypoint (often call vectors) that will execute necessary code to setup a correct state for kernel mode execution.
- The kernel takes care of saving registers, switching to the kernel stack and potentially other things depending on the architecture.
  - Does not use the user stack but a specific kernel fixed size stack for security purposes.

Exceptions

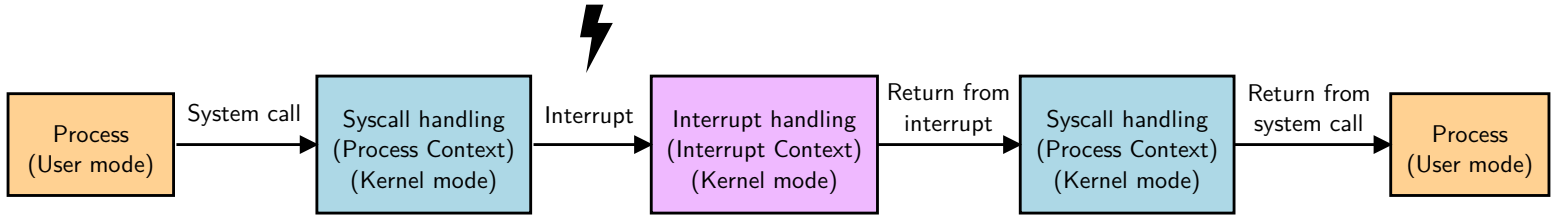
- Exceptions designate the kind of events that will trigger a CPU execution mode change to handle the exception.
- Two main types of exceptions exist: synchronous and asynchronous.
  - Asynchronous exceptions when a fault happens while executing (MMU, bus abort, etc) or when an interrupt is received (either software or hardware).
  - Synchronous when executing some specific instructions (breakpoint, syscall, etc)
- When such exception is triggered, the processor will jump to the exception vector and execute the code that was setup for this exception.

Interrupts

- Interrupts are asynchronous signals that are generated by the hardware peripherals.
  - Can also be synchronous when generated using a specific instruction (**I**nter **P**rocessor **I**nterrupts for instance).
- When receiving an interrupt, the CPU will change its execution mode by jumping to a specific vector and switching to kernel mode to handle the interrupt.
- When multiple CPUs (cores) are present, interrupts are often directed to a single core.
- This is called "IRQ affinity" and it allows to control the IRQ load for each CPU
  - See core-api/irq/irq-affinity and `man irqbalance(1)`

Interrupt context

- While handling the interrupts, the kernel is executing in a specific context named *interrupt context*.
- This context does not have access to userspace and should not use get_current() .
- Depending on the architecture, might use an IRQ stack.
- Interrupts are disabled (no nested interrupt support)!



System Calls (1/2)

- A system call allows the user space to request services from the kernel by executing a special instruction that will switch to the kernel mode (man2syscall)
  - When executing functions provided by the libc (`read()` ,

    ```
    write()
    ```

    , etc), they often end up executing a system call.
- System calls are identified by a numeric identifier that is passed via the registers.
  - The kernel exports some defines (in `unistd.h`) that are named `__NR_<sycall>` and defines the syscall identifiers.

```
#define __NR_read 63
#define __NR_write 64
```

System Calls (2/2)

- The kernel holds a table of function pointers which matches these identifiers and will invoke the correct handler after checking the validity of the syscall.
- System call parameters are passed via registers (up to 6).
- When executing this instruction the CPU will change its execution state and switch to the kernel mode.
- Each architecture uses a specific hardware mechanism (man2syscall)

```
mov w8, #__NR_getpid
svc #0
tstne x0, x1
```

Kernel execution contexts

Kernel execution contexts

- The kernel runs code in various contexts depending on the event it is handling.
- Might have interrupts disabled, specific stack, etc.

Kernel threads

- Kernel threads (kthreads) are a special kind of struct task_struct that do not have any user resources associated (`mm == NULL`).
- These processes are cloned from the `kthreadd` process and can be created using kthread_create() .
- Kernel threads are scheduled and are allowed to sleep much like a process executing in process context.
- Kernel threads are visible and their names are displayed between brackets under *ps*:

```
$ ps --ppid 2 -p 2 -o uname,pid,ppid,cmd,cls USER         PID    PPID CMD
CLS
root           2       0 [kthreadd]                    TS
root           3       2 [rcu_gp]                      TS
root           4       2 [rcu_par_gp]                  TS
root           5       2 [netns]                       TS
```

Kernel threads

```
root           7       2 [kworker/0:0H-events_highpr  TS
root          10       2 [mm_percpu_wq]               TS
root          11       2 [rcu_tasks_kthread]          TS
```

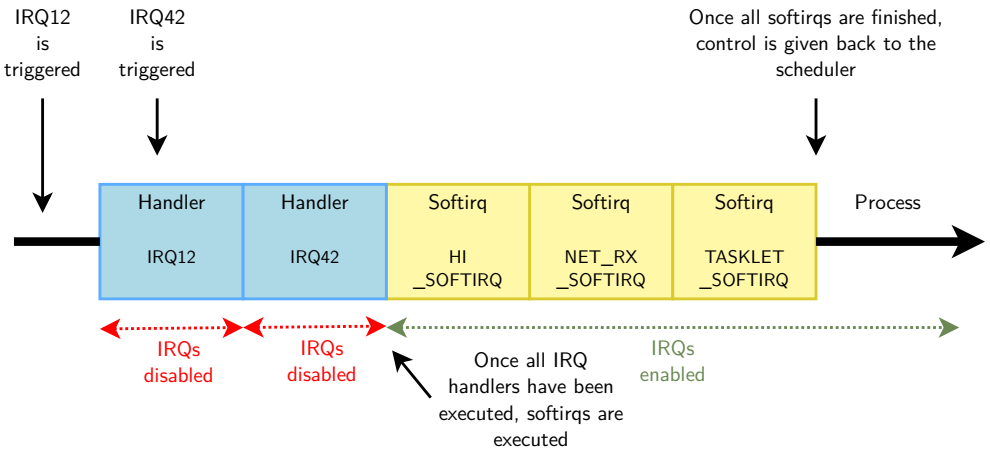
Workqueues

- Workqueues allows to schedule some work to be executed at some point in the future
- Workqueues are executing the work functions in kernel threads.
  - Allows to sleep while executing the deferred work.
  - Interrupts are enabled while executing
- Work can be executed either in dedicated work queues or in the default workqueue that is shared by multiple users.

softirq

- SoftIRQs is a specific kernel mecanism that is executed in software interrupt context.
- Allows to execute code that needs to be deferred after interrupt handling but needs low latency.
  - Executed right after hardware IRQ have been handled in interrupt context.
  - Same context as executing interrupt handler so sleeping is not allowed.
- Anyone wanting to run some code in softirq context should likely not create its own but prefer some entities implemented on top of it. There are for example tasklets, and the BH workqueues (Bottom Half workqueues) which aim to replace tasklets since 6.9.

Interrupts & Softirqs



Threaded interrupts

- Threaded interrupts are a mecanism that allows to handle the interrupt using a hard IRQ handler and a threaded IRQ handler.
  - Created calling request_threaded_irq() instead of request_irq()
- A threaded IRQ handler will allow to execute work that can potentially sleep in a kthread.
- One kthread is created for each interrupt line that was requested as a threaded IRQ.
  - *kthread* is named `irq/<irq>-<name>` and can be seen using *ps*.

Allocations and context

- Allocating memory in the kernel can be done using multiple functions:
  - `void *kmalloc(size_t size, gfp_t gfp_mask);`
  - `void *kzalloc(size_t size, gfp_t gfp_mask);`
  -
    ```
    unsigned long __get_free_pages(gfp_t gfp_mask, unsigned
    int order)
    ```
- All allocation functions take a `gfp_mask` parameter which allows to designate the kind of memory that is needed.
  - GFP_KERNEL : Normal allocation, can sleep while allocating memory (can not be used in interrupt context).
  - GFP_ATOMIC : Atomic allocation, won't sleep while allocating data.

Preparing the system

Allocations and context

Prepare the STM32MP157D board

- Build an image using Buildroot
- Connect the board
- Load the kernel from SD card
- Mount the root filesystem over NFS